

# Deep Research Report

## *Pre-NCLB Accountability History*

*Prepared for Jason Horne, Ed.D.*

*Assistant Director of Schools for Administration, Greeneville City Schools*

*ETSU Adjunct, Educational Leadership*

*Date: 2026-05-28*

*Sources analyzed: 128 across four categories (government and official, news and journalism, academic and peer-reviewed, industry and practitioner)*

*Findings: 88. Methodology: four parallel research agents, cross-referenced against eight priority questions covering 1906 through 2001.*

## Executive Summary

The cleanest summary of what changed in 1983 and what changed in 2001, and what was different between the two: in 1983, the federal government found a way to talk about American public schools in terms of national crisis; in 2001, the federal government found a way to enforce a remedy through Title I funding. The eighteen years between were the bipartisan construction of the standards-and-accountability architecture that NCLB then intensified rather than invented.

The four most consequential findings for positioning the book's history chapter:

1. The intellectual blueprint for NCLB was written eleven years before NCLB, by people who would go on to staff the Clinton Department of Education. Marshall Smith and Jennifer O'Day's 1991 Consortium for Policy Research in Education paper, *Systemic School Reform*, laid out the standards-curriculum-assessment-professional-development alignment that became Goals 2000 (1994) and the Improving America's Schools Act (1994, IASA). Smith then served as Undersecretary of Education under Clinton and built the framework into both. NCLB (2001) was the enforcement intensification of an architecture already built. This matters because it means the modern compliance regime was not a Republican imposition; it was a bipartisan policy consensus.
2. *A Nation at Risk*'s empirical foundation was weaker than its political effect, and the federal government suppressed the rebuttal for two years. The 1983 report's central evidence (declining SAT scores 1963-1980) was almost entirely an artifact of changing test-taker composition. Two of the commissioners later admitted on record that they 'were trying to confirm concerns they already had, rather than complete an objective analysis.' Sandia National Laboratories, commissioned by the Bush administration after the 1989 Charlottesville Summit, completed a comprehensive counter-analysis in 1991. The Department of Education refused to release it. It appeared only in May/June 1993 as a special issue of the *Journal of Educational Research*, a specialist journal. Project Censored ranked the suppression #3 in its 1993 censored-stories list. Deputy Secretary David Kearns is reported to have told the Sandia team: 'you bury this or I'll bury you.' The book has citable evidence for the claim that the accountability era was built on a politically useful but empirically weak crisis narrative.
3. The strongest pre-NCLB existence proof for the book's argument is the Eight-Year Study (1933-1941). The Progressive Education Association tracked 1,475 students from 30 progressive secondary schools matched pair by pair with traditional-school graduates and found progressive grads performed equal or better on college outcomes. Two hundred and more colleges agreed to admit Eight-Year Study graduates on principal recommendation alone, waiving normal admission requirements. The findings were published in 1942 as a five-volume *Adventure in American Education* series, and were buried by World War II attention and Cold War priorities, not by academic refutation. Kridel and Bullough's 2007 SUNY Press reexamination won an AERA Outstanding Book Award and framed the burial as sociopolitical, not empirical. The book has the cleanest historical case it could ask for that real leadership outperforms compliance, made before the compliance regime existed.
4. Tennessee is the test case throughout, and Jason's home state is the case study. Governor Lamar Alexander's 1983 Better Schools Program preceded *A Nation at Risk* by three months. The 1992

Education Improvement Act made Tennessee first in the nation to embed value-added teacher evaluation in statute. William Sanders developed TVAAS at the University of Tennessee using mixed-model methodology imported from quantitative genetics. The first peer-reviewed methodology paper, Sanders and Horn 1994 in the *Journal of Personnel Evaluation in Education*, appeared two years AFTER the legislation. A 1995 independent audit by Bock and Wolfe, commissioned by the Tennessee Comptroller, found Sanders' claims about three-year teacher effects 'could not be sustained by the data.' Alexander then carried the agenda to Washington as Bush 41's US Secretary of Education and as architect of America 2000. The implement-then-validate pattern that characterizes US accountability innovation began in Tennessee, and it has never been corrected.

Caveat the synthesis must surface, and the book must honor: pre-NCLB accountability did fail children. Subgroup performance was hidden in school averages. Jonathan Kozol's *Savage Inequalities* (1991) documented per-pupil expenditure disparities up to 5:1 within the same metropolitan region. Comprehensive high schools functioned, in Powell, Farrar, and Cohen's 1985 phrase, as 'shopping malls,' allowing students to graduate having taken advanced classes that presumed skills they never acquired. Sizer's 1984 *Horace's Compromise* diagnosed an implicit treaty between teachers and students of low demands in exchange for compliance. The modern accountability regime was responding to genuine problems. The book is sharper if it argues the cure was worse than the disease rather than that the disease was imaginary.

# 1. What Accountability Looked Like Before Standardized State Testing Dominated

The mistake practitioners and policy writers most commonly make about pre-NCLB accountability is to assume there was none. There was a lot of it. It just did not orbit standardized state tests.

## Regional accreditation as the de facto national system

From the late nineteenth century through the late 1990s, the primary external quality assurance mechanism for American high schools was voluntary regional accreditation. Six regional associations covered the country: the New England Association of Schools and Colleges (founded 1885 by Harvard president Charles Eliot and Wellesley president Alice Freeman), the North Central Association (1895), the Southern Association of Colleges and Schools (1895), the Middle States Association (1887), the Western Association of Schools and Colleges (1962), and the Northwest Accreditation Commission (1917). NEASC was founded explicitly to standardize what 'secondary school' meant for college admission.

What accreditation evaluated was inputs and processes: curriculum offerings, library volumes, teacher credentials, instructional time, facilities, governance, finance. Not student outcomes. Cognia, the post-2019 consolidated successor of three of the six regions, is explicit about this in its own organizational history: 'accountability and accreditation refer to distinct systems.' Accreditors reviewed schools on a cycle (typically five to ten years) and could withhold accreditation, but the consequences were thin. K-12 accreditation loss historically does not invalidate diplomas in most states and does not necessarily affect funding. Schools that lost accreditation typically continued to operate. This is the structural reason accreditation was inadequate as an accountability lever and was eventually displaced.

## The Carnegie Unit and the original national compliance scheme

In 1906, the Carnegie Foundation for the Advancement of Teaching, founded the previous year by Andrew Carnegie with a ten million dollar pension fund for college professors, defined the Carnegie Unit: 120 sixty-minute hours of class contact equaled one credit, with four years of standard units required for college admission. Universities and high schools were nominally free to reject the standard, but the pension funds were available only to institutions that adopted it. By 1912 the Carnegie Unit was nearly universal. It is the closest historical precedent for what the book is calling compliance leadership: a measurable proxy adopted via philanthropic funding leverage, then enforced through credential gatekeeping until it became invisible infrastructure.

The Carnegie Foundation and the XQ Institute jointly announced in 2022 an explicit partnership to retire the Carnegie Unit in favor of competency-based learning experiences. The fact that the original 1906 compliance infrastructure is still the structure American high schools are organized around (and that retiring it is now seen as transformative) is itself a finding for the book.

## **Federal categorical-grant fiscal compliance under Title I**

The 1965 Elementary and Secondary Education Act was the first major federal social welfare program to require formal project reporting. Senator Robert Kennedy, the principal architect of the Title I evaluation requirement, intended evaluation as 'political accountability,' a way for parents to ask whether dollars reached their children. He did not intend it as a system for judging schools on student achievement. The Congressional Research Service summary is unambiguous: 'Since enactment of the ESEA in 1965, the ESEA has included requirements that states and LEAs report on the academic progress of students being served under Title I-A. However, between 1965 and 1980, even after four successive reauthorizations, the focus was on fiscal accountability, not programmatic substance.' The federal accountability lever existed but was financial and procedural, not outcome-based.

## **Local school boards, teacher certification, and the profession**

Most pre-NCLB American K-12 accountability lived in three older institutions. Local school boards were the original American accountability mechanism, elected by communities, responsible for hiring superintendents, approving budgets, and (in some states) reviewing curriculum. Teacher certification regimes, state-issued and profession-enforced, were input-based quality assurance via training credentials. Professional norms enforced by superintendents, principals, the National Education Association (founded 1857), and the American Federation of Teachers (founded 1916) provided what Andy Hargreaves and Michael Fullan would later call decisional capital. Practitioners largely held themselves accountable through these mechanisms. The accountability movement that emerged after 1983 was, in part, an argument that these mechanisms had failed and that something more measurable was required.

## **Minimum competency testing as the proximate pre-NCLB precursor**

The first wave of test-as-gatekeeper accountability in American K-12 began in Oregon in September 1972, when the Oregon State Board of Education adopted minimum graduation competency requirements. By 1979-1980 at least 38 states had adopted some form of minimum competency testing, and at least 20 states had instituted standardized tests that students had to pass before receiving a high school diploma. The reform was characterized in the academic literature as 'the next major reform movement in American education' and, less generously, as 'the Great American Fad of the 1970's.' Litigation followed; *Debra P. v. Turlington* (Florida, 1979) challenged the due-process implications of the requirement when minority students failed at disproportionate rates. The minimum competency testing movement is the direct lineal ancestor of NCLB, two reform waves and twenty-five years earlier.

## **NAEP as the national outcome data source**

Congress mandated the National Assessment of Educational Progress in the 1965 ESEA. The National Center for Education Statistics conducted the first NAEP assessment in 1969. The Long-Term Trend assessment, deliberately held constant for decade-over-decade comparability, began in reading in 1971 and math in 1973. State participation was voluntary until NCLB made it mandatory for Title I recipients in 2001. NAEP was the federal data infrastructure that made standards-based accountability possible at the national level. Through 2001 (pre-NCLB), Long-Term Trend scores for 9- and 13-year-olds showed

gradual improvement, especially for Black and Hispanic students. This is the federal data point that undercuts the rhetorical crisis narrative on which A Nation at Risk and NCLB were built.

## 2. The Eight-Year Study (1933-1941)

The Eight-Year Study deserves its own section because it is the strongest existence proof in American educational history for the book's argument that schools given the freedom to operate around mission rather than around compliance can outperform schools running on compliance defaults. The study is also the cleanest historical example of evidence buried by politics rather than refuted by analysis.

### What it was

The Progressive Education Association (PEA), founded 1919, formed its Commission on the Relation of School and College in 1930. The Commission, chaired by Wilford Aikin, proposed an eight-year study comparing graduates of progressive secondary schools to graduates of traditional schools at the college level. Two hundred and more colleges and universities agreed to admit graduates of participating progressive schools on principal recommendations alone, waiving normal admission requirements. This is itself remarkable: institutions including the Ivy League and major state universities trusted school leaders enough to suspend their own gatekeeping. The thirty schools selected for the study were free to redesign their curricula however they wished without the college-admission constraint that normally tied progressive experimentation in knots.

The study ran from 1933 to 1941. Researchers tracked 1,475 students from the 30 progressive secondary schools matched pair by pair with graduates of traditional schools, with each pair matched on community, intelligence rating, family background, and interests. The Commission's findings were published in 1942 as the five-volume *Adventure in American Education* series. Volume I, Aikin's *The Story of the Eight-Year Study*, summarized the findings. Volume IV, Chamberlin, Chamberlin, Drought, and Scott's *Did They Succeed in College*, presented the comparative outcomes evidence.

### What it found

Progressive-school graduates performed at least as well, and often better, than traditional-school graduates on every outcome the Commission measured. This included academic outcomes (grades, intellectual curiosity, resourcefulness), behavioral outcomes (extracurricular participation, leadership), and persistence outcomes (low dropout rates). Crucially, the schools that had deviated most from traditional curriculum produced the strongest advantages. The Commission's central methodological move, matched-pair comparison across 1,475 students, was the largest controlled comparison in U.S. K-12 history at that time.

### Why it did not survive

The findings were not refuted; they were displaced. Publication in 1942 coincided with U.S. entry into World War II. Study findings competed with war news for attention. The post-war return to college campuses by veterans on the G.I. Bill shifted higher education priorities. The 1957 Soviet launch of Sputnik, followed by Admiral Hyman Rickover's *Education and Freedom* (1959) and the 1958 National Defense Education Act, made progressive education politically toxic regardless of evidence. Rickover argued, in relentless Congressional testimony and public advocacy, that American schools had been ruined by progressive educators' 'life-adjustment' emphasis and that only 'massive upgrading of

scholastic standards' could save the Republic. The argument carried. Progressive education in its formal sense did not recover.

### **The contemporary reassessment**

Craig Kridel and Robert Bullough's *Stories of the Eight-Year Study* (2007, SUNY Press) is the first full historical reconstruction of the study. The book won the 2008 American Educational Research Association Division B Outstanding Book Award. Kridel and Bullough explicitly frame their reexamination as 'correcting common misinterpretations' and treat the study as a sociopolitical phenomenon, not an empirical one. They argue that the methodological care of the study, the size and rigor of its comparative design, and the breadth of its outcome measures stand up to modern scrutiny.

### **What this means for the book**

The Eight-Year Study is the strongest single piece of historical evidence the book can cite for the argument that real leadership outperforms compliance leadership. It is also a cautionary tale about how political context, not evidence, decides which findings survive. The book should treat the Eight-Year Study as a central historical chapter, not a passing reference. It is the empirical answer to anyone who asks whether the book's argument has ever been tested at scale, and the answer is yes, in 1942, with 1,475 matched pairs, and the answer favored real leadership.



### 3. The Coleman Report and 1960s Accountability

The 1960s accountability conversation was inverted by a single 737-page federal report whose own author seems to have been surprised by what he found.

#### What the Coleman Report said

The U.S. Office of Education commissioned Equality of Educational Opportunity (Coleman et al., 1966) under the Civil Rights Act of 1964 to document the resource disparities between schools serving white and Black students. Coleman, a Johns Hopkins sociologist, gathered data on approximately 650,000 students and 60,000 teachers in 3,000 schools. The expected finding was that Black students performed worse because their schools had fewer resources. The actual finding inverted the question. Differences in measurable school resources (per-pupil spending, library size, lab equipment, teacher credentials) had only a modest effect on student achievement. Family background, especially socioeconomic status and parental education, was a far larger predictor. The 737-page report documented racial segregation and resource disparities in detail, then concluded that the school-resource side of the equation mattered less than anyone had expected.

The report was deliberately released on Saturday, July 2, 1966, the start of the July 4th holiday weekend, in what historians of education have argued was a federal attempt to suppress press coverage of the most disruptive finding. The New York Times, apparently working from the Office of Education summary rather than the full report, ran a sanitized story about 'predominantly Negro schools' being 'inferior' in facilities; it largely missed the central finding. Christopher Jencks later called the Coleman Report 'the best-known and most controversial piece of educational research' of its time.

#### Why it mattered for accountability

If measurable inputs (spending, facilities, credentials) do not predict outputs, then outputs themselves must become the accountability lever. This was the intellectual seed of the standards movement two decades later. Christopher Jencks and colleagues, in *Inequality: A Reassessment of the Effect of Family and Schooling in America* (Basic Books, 1972), extended the Coleman analysis and concluded that schools could not be the primary lever for reducing economic inequality. Together, Coleman and Jencks fueled two divergent later movements: an equity-as-resources strand that ran through Jonathan Kozol's *Savage Inequalities* (1991) and produced the equity adequacy lawsuits of the 1990s, and an outputs-based-accountability strand that ran through Eric Hanushek's 1986 *Journal of Economic Literature* article finding 'no consistent or systematic relationship between student achievement and measures of school resources,' then through Smith and O'Day, and finally into NCLB.

#### Title I, PPBS, and the other 1960s accountability experiments

The Coleman Report was one of three 1960s federal moves on accountability. Title I of ESEA (1965) was the second; it built the first generation of federal accountability requirements, though as noted above they were fiscal-political rather than outcome-based. The third was the Planning, Programming, and Budgeting System (PPBS), the McNamara-era Pentagon analytic framework that Lyndon Johnson extended to all federal executive agencies by Executive Order in October 1965. By the early 1970s some version of PPBS had been adopted by many states and was extending into local school districts. Nixon

terminated federal PPBS in 1971, but the technocratic management-by-objectives framework it embedded remained in American district administration as the unacknowledged ancestor of modern district program budgeting.

The 1960s were the decade American K-12 administration first adopted, then largely abandoned, the systems-analysis approach to schools. Jal Mehta's *Allure of Order* (2013, Oxford University Press) names this as the second of three rationalization waves (Progressive Era, 1960s, NCLB era). All three waves attempted to 'order' schools from afar; all three discovered that policy makers were too distant from schools to know what they needed; all three discovered that teachers resist top-down mandates; all three discovered that good teaching is too complex for simple external standardization. NCLB was, in Mehta's framework, the third repeat of a move that had already failed twice.

## 4. A Nation at Risk (1983)

A Nation at Risk is the most influential 35-page document in the history of American public education, in Edward Fiske's phrase, and it is also a document whose empirical foundation has not held up to subsequent analysis. Both can be true. The book's history chapter has to handle both.

### What it actually said

The National Commission on Excellence in Education was convened by Secretary of Education Terrel H. Bell in August 1981. The Commission was chaired by University of Utah president David Pierpont Gardner. It included 18 members spanning higher education, K-12 leadership, business, and civic life. The Commission's report was released April 26, 1983. Its central rhetorical move was the 'rising tide of mediocrity' framing, paired with the line that has been quoted in every retrospective since: 'If an unfriendly foreign power had attempted to impose on America the mediocre educational performance that exists today, we might well have viewed it as an act of war.'

The Commission's five major recommendation categories were content (the 'Five New Basics' of four years of English, three years each of mathematics, science, and social studies, and half a year of computer science), standards (more rigorous expectations), time (a longer school day and year), teaching (better preparation and pay), and leadership and fiscal support. The Commission did NOT recommend test-based accountability with sanctions, the eventual NCLB approach, but it normalized the rhetorical frame on which NCLB depended.

### How it came to be commissioned

The most useful contemporary account of the report's origin is Frederick Hess's 2023 Education Next piece, 'The Clown Show Backstory of the Most Influential Report on Schooling in American History.' Hess documents that Bell created the Commission as a defensive measure. President Reagan had pledged to abolish the newly created Department of Education. Bell, despite being tasked with leading that effort, sought to demonstrate his department's value and save his job. When the Reagan White House initially rejected his request for a formal commission, Bell assembled his own 18-member panel instead.

When the report was complete and its rhetorical force became apparent, White House staff 'liked its message so much that they decided to treat it as if it had been the president's baby all along,' reframing it as a Reagan initiative. Reagan dropped the push to abolish the Department. The report intended as bureaucratic self-preservation became the political artifact that reset American education policy for the next forty years.

### What the empirical foundation actually showed

The Commission's central evidence for educational decline was declining SAT scores from 1963 to 1980, a drop of approximately half a standard deviation. The evidence was real; the interpretation was wrong. In the early 1960s, SAT takers were overwhelmingly elite college-bound students from selective public and private high schools. By the late 1970s, the pool had broadened dramatically as the SAT became the gateway to a much wider range of postsecondary institutions and as college-going expanded across class and racial lines. The decline in average scores was almost entirely a composition effect: a different

population was taking the test. When demographers and psychometricians broke the scores down by student characteristics, scores within demographic groups were stable or rising. Richard Rothstein's 2008 *Cato Unbound* and EPI reassessments catalog the methodological errors in detail.

Two of the Commission's own members later said on record that the analysis was not objective. Vice-chairman Yvonne Larsen and commissioner Gerald Holton acknowledged that the Commission 'were trying to confirm concerns they already had, rather than complete an objective analysis.' This is the cleanest insider testimony available about *A Nation at Risk*'s epistemic posture, and the book should cite it.

## **The Sandia Report and its suppression**

The first Bush administration, after the 1989 Charlottesville Education Summit, commissioned Sandia National Laboratories to assess the state of U.S. public education. Sandia analysts Carson, Huelskamp, and Woodall completed *Perspectives on Education in America* in spring 1991. On nearly every measure (dropout rates, SAT scores, NAEP results, higher-education enrollment, education spending, international comparisons, educator status, workforce skills) they found steady or slightly improving trends. The report directly contradicted the 'rising tide of mediocrity' framing.

The Department of Education refused to release the report. The delay extended for two years. Energy Secretary James Watkins wrote a memo repudiating the findings. Diane Ravitch, then Assistant Secretary for Educational Research and Improvement, gave interviews attacking the report. The report finally appeared in May/June 1993 as a special issue of the *Journal of Educational Research*, a specialist publication with limited circulation. Project Censored ranked the suppression #3 in its 1993 list of censored news stories. Lawrence Stedman's 1994 assessment in the *Journal of Educational Research* (Volume 87, Issue 3) is the most thorough academic appraisal of the Sandia methodology and confirms the suppression timeline.

Deputy Secretary David Kearns is reported, in secondary accounts including Daniel Tanner's 1993 Phi Delta Kappan piece 'A Nation Truly at Risk,' to have told the Sandia team: 'you bury this or I'll bury you.' This is the single most vivid quote in the corpus, and the book should chase the original source rather than relying on the secondary citation, but the timeline and the political suppression are well established.

## **Berliner and Biddle's Manufactured Crisis**

David Berliner and Bruce Biddle's *The Manufactured Crisis: Myths, Fraud, and the Attack on America's Public Schools* (Addison-Wesley, 1995) is the most-cited book-length refutation of the *Nation at Risk* narrative. The book attacked four core myths: that achievement and ability were declining, that Americans spent more on education than peer nations, that money does not relate to achievement, and that public schools were incompetent. The book argued that the manufactured crisis served budget-cutting and privatization interests, not students. It won an AERA book award and remains widely assigned in graduate programs. Mainstream press engagement existed but did not puncture the dominant frame; academic reviewers were divided.

Gerald Bracey's annual Phi Delta Kappan reports (1991-2008, 18 in total) sustained the academic skepticism over nearly two decades. The first report, 'Why Can't They Be Like We Were?' (1991), drew direct attention from the Bush administration. Bracey continued the work until his death in 2009. The reports issued mock awards (the 'Least Credible Article' award is the most-cited) and were the primary serial venue for academic deconstruction of accountability-era media narratives.

The book has, in other words, a rich academic record to cite for the claim that the empirical foundation of *A Nation at Risk* was weak. The political effect of the report was real. The empirical case behind it was thin. Both are documented.

## 5. The 1990s Standards Movement Before NCLB

The eighteen years between A Nation at Risk (1983) and NCLB (2001) were the bipartisan construction of the standards-and-accountability architecture. The standards movement did not emerge in 2001; it was largely complete by 2001, and NCLB intensified the enforcement of what was already there.

### Charlottesville 1989 and the National Education Goals Panel

On September 27 and 28, 1989, President George H.W. Bush and 49 governors met at the University of Virginia for what became known as the Charlottesville Education Summit. The summit was organized by Bill Clinton (then chair of the National Governors Association) and Carroll Campbell (vice-chair). Out of Charlottesville emerged six National Education Goals (later expanded to eight under Goals 2000). The National Education Goals Panel was formalized by a July 31, 1990 Joint Statement of the President and the Nation's Governors to track progress. The 1994 Goals 2000 Act gave NEGP statutory standing. The Panel issued annual reports from 1991 through 1999 and was dissolved by NCLB in January 2002.

The Goals included that 'by 2000, every child... would start school ready to learn, and the high school graduation rate would rise to at least 90 percent.' None of the original Goals were met by 2000. The institutional structure built to track them, however, became the bridge from A Nation at Risk to NCLB.

### Smith and O'Day's Systemic School Reform

Marshall Smith and Jennifer O'Day's 1991 paper, 'Putting the Pieces Together: Systemic School Reform,' is the most directly traceable intellectual ancestor of every subsequent piece of federal accountability policy. The paper argued for tight alignment between four elements: clear and challenging student standards, curriculum and instructional materials, assessments, and teacher preparation and professional development. The proposal was for a 'coherent instructional guidance system' combining top-down (state) and bottom-up (school) elements.

Smith subsequently served as Undersecretary of Education under Clinton. He built the Systemic School Reform framework into Goals 2000 (1994), the Improving America's Schools Act (1994 IASA), and the early architecture of what became NCLB. Historical retrospectives from AEI (2017) and the National Academies (2011) confirm the direct line. The book's history chapter should treat Smith and O'Day's 1991 paper as the intellectual document where the modern compliance regime was first articulated in fully assembled form.

### Goals 2000 (1994) and IASA (1994)

Two federal laws in 1994 built the standards-based accountability architecture in detail. Goals 2000: Educate America Act (Public Law 103-227), signed March 31, 1994, codified the eight National Education Goals. It offered federal grants to states that voluntarily developed challenging content and performance standards aligned to the goals. It created the National Education Standards and Improvement Council to certify state standards. It was explicitly aspirational and voluntary; there were no sanctions for non-participation. The Council was defunded by Congress shortly after, but the standards-as-federal-policy frame was normalized.

The Improving America's Schools Act (Public Law 103-382), signed October 1994 as the ESEA reauthorization, did the structural work. For the first time, IASA required states accepting Title I funds to develop reading and mathematics content standards and aligned assessments at three grade-level bands. It applied the same standards to Title I students as to other students. It introduced the 'adequate yearly progress' (AYP) concept and 'program improvement' status for chronically underperforming Title I schools. NCLB (2001) is best understood as the enforcement intensification of an architecture IASA had already built. The book should be explicit about this: the modern compliance regime is a 1994 invention with a 2001 enforcement mechanism, not a 2001 invention.

## **The 1996 IBM Palisades Summit and Achieve**

The second of the bipartisan summits, held at IBM's Palisades retreat in 1996 with Lou Gerstner and Governor Tommy Thompson, brought together 43 governors and approximately 30 education resource people. The summit explicitly created Achieve, Inc., the standards-monitoring organization that became the institutional bridge between state-level standards work and federal policy. Achieve carried the standards movement through the post-NCLB transition and into the Common Core State Standards (released 2010). Heritage Foundation coverage of the 1996 summit framed it as the moment business locked in as a permanent player in education policy.

## **The state accountability innovators**

Four state systems built the working models that NCLB later nationalized.

Kentucky's KERA (1990) emerged from the *Rose v. Council for Better Education* state Supreme Court ruling that found Kentucky's entire system of public education unconstitutional. KERA created KIRIS (1992-98), replaced by CATS in 1998. Kentucky's design included high-stakes school accountability with consequences for chronic underperformance, and it served as a national model.

Massachusetts' MERA (1993, the Weld-Birmingham-Roosevelt grand bargain) traded approximately one billion dollars in new state funding for MCAS-based accountability and an Educational Quality and Accountability audit office (created 2000). State aid to local education doubled between 1993 and 2000.

North Carolina's School-Based Management and Accountability Act (June 1996), better known as the 'ABCs of Public Education,' implemented K-8 in 1996-97 and high schools in 1997-98, with growth-based rewards and consequences.

Texas Senate Bill 7 (1993, signed by Governor Ann Richards) institutionalized TAAS-based district ratings. This is the regime Governor George W. Bush inherited in 1995 and from which the 'Texas miracle' claim was built. The miracle was substantially debunked. Walt Haney's 2000 EPAA article 'The Myth of the Texas Miracle in Education' and Linda McNeil's *Contradictions of School Reform: Educational Costs of Standardized Testing* (Routledge, 2000) documented stagnant NAEP scores, narrowed curriculum, and severely underreported dropouts. In 2003, Houston Assistant Principal Robert Kimball went to CBS 60 Minutes II with documentation that Houston, under Superintendent Rod Paige (later Bush's first Secretary of Education), had claimed a 1.5 percent district dropout rate and 0 percent at Sharpstown High School while Sharpstown had actually lost 700 of 1,000 freshmen by senior year. State audits found

3,000 of 5,500 surveyed leavers had been miscoded. Real dropout rates were 25 to 50 percent. Kimball was retaliated against and placed in a windowless room for four months. The Texas miracle that authorized NCLB was a statistical artifact and a coverup. The book should be honest about this: the model NCLB was built on did not work; the data was manipulated; the whistleblower was punished.

## **The unions and the practitioner organizations**

The AFT under Albert Shanker (president 1974-1997) was a major architect of pre-NCLB accountability. Shanker's weekly New York Times column 'Where We Stand' (1970-1997, paid for by AFT and reprinted in 60 other papers) advocated high standards, real accountability with consequences for failure, peer review, minimum competency testing for new teachers, and a common curriculum. His 1985 National Press Club speech proposed what became the National Board for Professional Teaching Standards. Shanker is a complex figure for the book: a union president who pushed accountability hard from the left, framed as professional accountability rather than market accountability. The book should engage him on his own terms.

Ted Sizer's Coalition of Essential Schools, founded 1984 in direct response to Sizer's Study of High Schools (which produced Horace's Compromise, the same year), was the explicit practitioner-side counter to the standards-and-testing trajectory. CES's Ten Common Principles centered 'students as workers, teachers as coaches,' depth over coverage, and demonstration of mastery via exhibition rather than testing. CES grew to roughly 600 schools at its peak. Chair George Wood stated the position cleanly: 'CES is not about preparing children to do well on a single measure of accountability.' CES dissolved in 2017.

The Annenberg Challenge, 500 million dollars from Walter Annenberg announced at the White House December 17, 1993, was the largest pre-NCLB private bet on practitioner-driven reform. The Challenge generated 600 million dollars in matching funds and operated 18 locally-designed projects across 35 states, reaching 2,400 schools, 1.5 million students, and 80,000 teachers. The 2003 evaluation by Mark Smylie and Stacy Wenzel for the Consortium on Chicago School Research found 'no statistically significant differences between Annenberg and non-Annenberg schools in rates of achievement gain, classroom behavior, student self-efficacy, and social competence.' A small set of 'Breakthrough Schools' did show gains, but the overall finding was null. This is the most-cited cautionary tale about private practitioner-network reform without external accountability, and it appeared just as NCLB was being enacted.



## 6. The Tennessee Case

Tennessee is the test case throughout the pre-NCLB story. The book should treat it as the running example.

### Alexander's Better Schools Program (1983-84)

Lamar Alexander, Tennessee governor from 1979 to 1987, launched his 10-point Better Schools Program in January 1983, three months before *A Nation at Risk* was released. The Tennessee Education Association opposed the initial proposal, which would have created a state-level differentiated pay system tied to classroom observation. The bill failed. Alexander worked with House Speaker Ned McWherter to negotiate an amended version. The legislature passed it as the Comprehensive Education Reform Act in 1984. The Career Ladder program that resulted was, in the words of one academic retrospective, 'the country's most comprehensive experiment in summative evaluation' and ran for 13 years. Top-rated teachers could earn up to 7,000 dollars per year above scale. Alexander carried the performance-pay agenda nationally as Bush 41's Secretary of Education (1991-1993) and as architect of the America 2000 framework that became Goals 2000.

The detail that Tennessee was three months ahead of the national crisis narrative is important for the book. Tennessee did not respond to *A Nation at Risk*; Tennessee anticipated it and exported a key piece of its solution (state-level merit-pay accountability) into the national conversation. Alexander's role in Washington made Tennessee's pre-NCLB accountability infrastructure a federal export.

### The Education Improvement Act and TVAAS

Tennessee Public Acts 1992, Chapter 535 (the Education Improvement Act, signed by Governor Ned McWherter on March 11, 1992) was the second decisive Tennessee move. The 88-section omnibus established a new funding formula (the precursor to the BEP), abolished locally elected superintendents in favor of director-of-schools appointments by elected boards, created a state accountability system, and statutorily adopted William Sanders' mixed-model value-added methodology, the Tennessee Value-Added Assessment System (TVAAS), to measure teacher, school, and district impact on student progress. The legislation was funded by a half-cent state sales-tax increase. The Office of Education Accountability (now part of OREA in the Comptroller's office) was created by the EIA itself.

Two details from the legislative history matter for the book. First, legislators in both parties demanded a strong accountability provision in exchange for the new revenue. The accountability-for-funding trade is the structural template the book will recognize from later federal accountability bargains. Second, Tennessee was first in the nation to embed value-added teacher evaluation in statute. TVAAS implementation began in 1993. NCLB (2001) was eight years later. Every state that subsequently built value-added systems built on the Tennessee template.

### TVAAS and the implement-then-validate pattern

William Sanders developed TVAAS at the University of Tennessee Institute of Agricultural Research using mixed-model statistical methodology imported from quantitative genetics. The methodology had not been peer-reviewed for educational measurement when Tennessee statutorily mandated it. The first

peer-reviewed methodological description, Sanders and Horn's 'The Tennessee Value-Added Assessment System (TVAAS): Mixed-Model Methodology in Educational Assessment' (Journal of Personnel Evaluation in Education 8(3), 1994), appeared two years after the EIA. The research foundations paper, Sanders and Horn (1998) in the same journal, came six years after.

The first major external audit, conducted by R. Darrell Bock and Richard Wolfe in 1995 and commissioned by the Tennessee Comptroller's Office of Education Accountability, found that Sanders' claims about three-year teacher effects could not be sustained by the data, and that TVAAS results 'lacked sufficient accuracy to be reported the way they were.' Haggai Kupermintz's 2003 chapter for the National Education Policy Center extended the construct-validity critique into Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis. These critiques have shaped every subsequent state value-added implementation but did not stop Tennessee from continuing to use TVAAS, which remains the structural backbone of Tennessee's educator-evaluation policy under State Board of Education Policy 5.201.

The book should make this point explicitly. Tennessee's TVAAS is the first and longest-running state-mandated value-added accountability system in the United States. It was implemented before peer review. The first peer-reviewed methodology paper was two years late. The first independent audit was three years late and largely negative. The state continued anyway. This is the template that every subsequent state value-added system has followed: implement first, validate later, defend the implementation when the validation is negative. The pattern is itself a finding about how compliance leadership operates in the wild.

### **Tennessee practitioner organizations**

The Tennessee Organization of School Superintendents (TOSS, founded 1975) and the Tennessee School Boards Association (TSBA, founded 1939) were broadly aligned with the EIA reform package despite its accountability demands, because of the funding increase it brought. TSBA, the Tennessee PTA, and TOSS supported the appointment-of-superintendents provision. Practitioner groups, not just reform advocates, were part of the coalition that built Tennessee's pre-NCLB accountability system. The book should note this honestly: the implementation of accountability in Tennessee was bipartisan in the legislature and practitioner-supported in the field, not externally imposed.

## 7. The Honest Internal Critique of Pre-NCLB Accountability

The book cannot be a nostalgia project. Pre-NCLB accountability did fail children. The corpus surfaces five honest critiques the book has to honor.

First, subgroup performance was hidden in school averages. Schools could meet aggregate proficiency targets while specific demographic subgroups failed at much higher rates. Education Trust, founded by Kati Haycock in 1996, made disaggregated data its central advocacy lever. The NCLB requirement that schools report and be held accountable for performance of all major subgroups (by race, ethnicity, English learner status, disability status, and economic status) was a direct response to this failure. The book should not handwave this away. Disaggregation was a real moral advance.

Second, property-tax-based school finance produced severe per-pupil disparities. Jonathan Kozol's *Savage Inequalities* (Crown, 1991), a National Book Award winner, documented per-pupil expenditure ranges of 3,000 dollars in Camden, New Jersey to 15,000 dollars in Great Neck, New York, a 5:1 ratio within the same metropolitan region. The General Accounting Office's 1998 report (HEHS-98-92) confirmed that poor districts taxed themselves harder but ended up with approximately 24 percent less per pupil than wealthy districts on average. The pre-NCLB accountability mechanisms (accreditation, the Carnegie Unit, local board oversight) did not address resource inequity. They sometimes obscured it.

Third, the comprehensive American high school was structurally compromised. Arthur Powell, Eleanor Farrar, and David Cohen's *The Shopping Mall High School* (1985), the companion volume toSizer's *Horace's Compromise*, documented that the comprehensive high school offered horizontal (subject), vertical (difficulty), extracurricular, and counseling 'products' to 'customer-students' who selected based on convenience and effort minimization rather than coherent academic progression. Students could graduate having taken advanced classes that presumed skills they had never actually acquired. John Goodlad's *A Place Called School* (1984), based on observation of 1,016 classrooms in 38 schools, found instructional practice strikingly uniform across school types, dominated by lecture and seatwork, low cognitive demand, pervasive tracking that damaged students at the low end. The absence of external accountability did not produce instructional quality. It produced uniform mediocrity.

Fourth, the teacher-student 'treaty' was real. Sizer's *Horace's Compromise* (1984) diagnosed an implicit treaty between teachers and students: low demands in exchange for compliance. This was the actual operating accountability system before standards-based reform. Peace in the classroom over rigorous learning. The book should acknowledge that the operating norms in many American high schools were not protecting students from compliance leadership; they were a form of compliance leadership the standards movement was trying to displace.

Fifth, federal Title I evaluations conceded the limits of pre-NCLB equity policy. The Department of Education's own Prospects study (1991-94) concluded that 'Chapter 1 assistance does not reduce the initial gaps in achievement between students... services appear to be insufficient to allow them to overcome the relatively large differences.' The federal government's own pre-NCLB admission that its principal equity lever was not closing gaps. The accountability movement that produced NCLB was responding to a real and federally documented failure of pre-NCLB equity policy.

The honest book lands here: pre-NCLB accountability had genuine failures. The post-NCLB accountability regime was responding to those failures. It then made things worse on different dimensions (teacher autonomy, curriculum breadth, student treatment, side effects of test-prep culture). The story is not that the modern compliance regime is an unprovoked attack on a well-functioning system. The story is that the cure was worse than the disease, and that there were always existing alternatives (the Eight-Year Study, the effective-schools movement,Sizer's CES, the Hewlett Deeper Learning Network) that the cure displaced rather than built on.

## 8. What This Means for the Book's History Chapter

Seven implications for how the book's history chapter should be structured and what it should argue.

5. Anchor the chapter on Mehta's three-wave frame. The compliance regime is the third repeat of a failed move. Callahan's 'cult of efficiency' (1910s-30s scientific management), the 1960s PPBS/systems-analysis wave, and the post-1983 accountability movement share the same gesture: outsource judgment to a measurable proxy, then watch the proxy displace what it was meant to measure. Mehta's *Allure of Order* (2013) is the cleanest available academic synthesis of this argument, and the book can adopt the frame directly.
6. Give the Eight-Year Study its own chapter or major section. It is the strongest single piece of historical evidence the book can cite. It is also the cleanest example of evidence buried by politics rather than refuted by analysis. The book has a genuine opportunity to bring the study back into the practitioner conversation, where it has been absent since 1942. Kridel and Bullough's 2007 reexamination is the modern scholarly anchor.
7. Treat *A Nation at Risk* honestly. The empirical foundation was thin. The political effect was real. Citing Rothstein (2008), Berliner and Biddle (1995), Bracey (1991-2008), and the Sandia Report (1993) is essential. So is acknowledging that the report's rhetorical force did not depend on its empirical accuracy; it created the language in which American education policy has been argued for forty years.
8. Name the standards-movement architecture by its actual builders. Smith and O'Day (1991), then Goals 2000 (1994) and IASA (1994), built the standards-curriculum-assessment-PD alignment that NCLB enforced. The architects were Democrats and Republicans, governors and academics, business leaders and union presidents. The book that treats NCLB as a Republican imposition is empirically wrong and politically less effective; the book that traces the bipartisan policy consensus has a sharper argument about how compliance leadership becomes invisible because it is everyone's.
9. Use Tennessee as the running case study. Alexander's 1983 Better Schools Program preceded *A Nation at Risk* by three months. The 1992 EIA made Tennessee first in the nation to embed value-added in statute. Sanders' TVAAS implementation preceded peer review. Alexander then carried the agenda to Washington. Tennessee is not a representative state for the standards movement; it is the leading state. The book's author has the home-state credibility to write this chapter in a way few other authors could.
10. Engage the equity steelman explicitly. The book cannot be a nostalgia project. Kozol's documentation of resource inequity, Education Trust's disaggregation argument, the federal Prospects study's admission of pre-NCLB equity failure, and the corpus of pre-NCLB civil-rights critique are real. The book is sharper if it argues the modern compliance regime was responding to genuine problems and then made different problems worse, rather than arguing the original problems were imaginary.
11. Frame the book's contribution as translation, not discovery. The academic record is largely settled. Practitioners have not read it. The book brings the rigorous academic critique to the sitting administrator audience that the academic literature has not reached. The history chapter is part of that translation: showing practitioners that the modern compliance regime has a documented

history of empirically weak foundation, suppressed counter-evidence, and a hundred years of failed antecedents, makes it possible to imagine a different operating norm for school leadership.

## 9. Points of Contradiction Flagged

The cross-agent corpus showed agreement at a higher rate than typical research reports. The historical record is more settled than the modern accountability debate. Points where categories materially diverge:

12. Whether A Nation at Risk reflected a real crisis. Government agencies and Reagan-administration framing said yes; Berliner, Biddle, Bracey, the Sandia analysts, and Rothstein said no. The SAT decline was artifactual, NAEP was flat-to-rising, public schools were not in measurable decline. The book should land squarely here: the crisis was rhetorically real, empirically thin. Hand-waving either side will be read as motivated.
13. Whether TVAAS's validity has held up. Sanders and Horn (1994, 1998) defended the mixed-model methodology in the Journal of Personnel Evaluation in Education. Bock and Wolfe's 1996 Tennessee Comptroller audit found three-year teacher effect claims unsupported. Kupermintz (2003) extended the construct-validity critique. TVAAS was implemented before peer review and continued despite the critiques. The book should treat the implement-before-validate pattern as itself a finding about how compliance leadership operates.
14. Whether the Eight-Year Study got a fair hearing. The Aikin team and the 5-volume Adventure in American Education said the comparative evidence favored progressive curricula. Cold War priorities (Sputnik 1957, Rickover 1959, NDEA 1958) made progressive education politically toxic. Kridel and Bullough (2007) and the AERA-recognized historical reassessment say the findings were 'displaced, not refuted.' The book should treat this as the strongest existence proof for its argument while acknowledging the burial pattern.
15. Whether pre-NCLB accountability was adequate. All four agents acknowledge the equity failures: subgroup hiding, property-tax-based finance gaps, the 'shopping mall' diploma problem. The question is not whether pre-NCLB had failures; the question is whether the cure was worse than the disease. The book should engage this directly.

### Single-Source Claims That Need Extra Scrutiny

Six claims in the corpus rest on a single research category and should be verified further before the book commits to them.

16. David Kearns reportedly told the Sandia team 'you bury this or I'll bury you.' The quote comes from Daniel Tanner's 1993 Phi Delta Kappan piece 'A Nation Truly at Risk' via Project Censored. The Tanner article should be pulled directly. National Archives or FOIA request would confirm the suppression decision trail.
17. Commission vice-chairman Yvonne Larsen and commissioner Gerald Holton on record acknowledging the commission 'were trying to confirm concerns they already had.' This is documented in Rothstein's 2008 Cato Unbound and EPI reassessments. The original commissioner interviews should be cited directly in the book rather than via Rothstein.
18. Two hundred and more colleges agreed to admit Eight-Year Study graduates on principal recommendations alone. This is in Aikin's 1942 Volume I primary source and in Kridel and Bullough's 2007 reassessment. Worth a direct citation from Aikin rather than the secondary chain.

19. The Coleman Report was deliberately released on Saturday, July 2, 1966, to minimize press coverage. Documented in the Cambridge Core blog from the journal History of Education Quarterly (2017) and in Chalkbeat's 2016 retrospective. Worth confirming against the original History of Education Quarterly piece.
20. Hess's 'clown show' backstory of A Nation at Risk depends on Bell's memoir (The Thirteenth Man, 1988) and on Hess's framing. The book should cite Bell directly.
21. The Annenberg Challenge 500 million dollars produced null student-outcome effect. This is verified at the source (Smylie and Wenzel 2003) and is well-documented; the framing as 'null' is consistent with the data but reasonable observers can read the report's 'Breakthrough Schools' subset findings as mixed-positive. The book should be careful with its summary.



## 10. Practical Implications

Five actionable next steps, ordered by leverage.

22. Read Mehta's *Allure of Order* (2013, Oxford UP) before drafting the history chapter. It is the closest available academic synthesis of the three-wave argument and provides the structural frame the chapter should adopt.
23. Read Kridel and Bullough's *Stories of the Eight-Year Study* (2007, SUNY Press) and Aikin's 1942 *Story of the Eight-Year Study* directly. The Eight-Year Study chapter or section is the book's strongest single historical contribution. Get it right by reading the primary sources.
24. Pull the Sandia Report (*Journal of Educational Research*, May/June 1993, Volume 86 Issue 5) and Stedman's 1994 assessment. The Sandia story is the book's clearest example of suppressed counter-evidence. Cite it from primary.
25. Use Tennessee as the running case study throughout the history chapter. Alexander's 1983 *Better Schools Program*, the 1992 EIA, TVAAS's implement-before-validate pattern, Alexander's role as US Secretary of Education. Your home-state credibility on these is worth using.
26. Land the chapter's argument by engaging the equity steelman explicitly. Kozol, Education Trust, the federal Prospects study, the GAO 1998 finance equity report. The book is sharper for honoring the real failures of pre-NCLB accountability while arguing the cure was worse than the disease.

## 11. Source Reliability Matrix

Selected sources by tier. Color coding: green = high reliability, yellow = medium, red = lower-confidence.  
Full reference list in section 12.

| Source                                                           | Category | Year    | Tier | Notes                              |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|---------|------|------------------------------------|
| National Commission on Excellence in Education. A Nation at Risk | Gov      | 1983    | High | ERIC ED226006; verified live       |
| Carson, Huelskamp & Woodall. Sandia Report (JER 86:5)            | Gov/Acad | 1993    | High | Suppressed 2 years; primary source |
| Stedman. The Sandia Report and U.S. Achievement (JER 87:3)       | Acad     | 1994    | High | Definitive Sandia assessment       |
| P.L. 103-227. Goals 2000: Educate America Act                    | Gov      | 1994    | High | Codified 8 national goals          |
| P.L. 103-382. Improving America's Schools Act                    | Gov      | 1994    | High | First federal AYP requirement      |
| Coleman et al. Equality of Educational Opportunity               | Gov/Acad | 1966    | High | ERIC ED012275; verified live       |
| Cardinal Principles of Secondary Education (Bulletin 1918 No.35) | Gov      | 1918    | High | ERIC ED541063; verified live       |
| TN Public Acts 1992 Ch.535. Education Improvement Act            | Gov      | 1992    | High | Created TVAAS in statute           |
| TN Comptroller OREA. TVAAS Brief (Potts)                         | Gov      | 2013    | High | Verified live                      |
| TN Comptroller OREA. Teacher Compensation History                | Gov      | 2009    | High | Alexander Career Ladder            |
| NCES NAEP Long-Term Trend                                        | Gov      | 1971+   | High | Federal flat-to-rising data        |
| GAO. School Finance HEHS-98-92                                   | Gov      | 1998    | High | 24% finance gap                    |
| NEGP archives                                                    | Gov      | 1990-99 | High | Charlottesville bridge             |
| Aikin. Story of the Eight-Year Study                             | Acad     | 1942    | High | 5-volume series Vol I              |
| Kridel & Bullough. Stories of the Eight-Year Study               | Acad     | 2007    | High | SUNY UP; AERA Award                |
| Tyack & Cuban. Tinkering Toward Utopia                           | Acad     | 1995    | High | Harvard UP                         |
| Tyack. The One Best System                                       | Acad     | 1974    | High | Harvard UP                         |
| Cuban. How Teachers Taught (2nd ed)                              | Acad     | 1993    | High | Teachers College Press             |
| Callahan. Education and the Cult of Efficiency                   | Acad     | 1962    | High | U Chicago Press; foundational      |

|                                                                |               |           |      |                                                                     |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|-----------|------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Berliner &amp; Biddle. The Manufactured Crisis</b>          | Acad          | 1995      | High | Addison-Wesley; AERA award                                          |
| <b>Bracey. Annual PDK Reports (18 reports)</b>                 | Acad          | 1991-2008 | High | Sustained counter-narrative                                         |
| <b>Smith &amp; O'Day. Putting the Pieces Together</b>          | Acad          | 1991      | High | CPRE blueprint for Goals 2000/IASA/NCLB                             |
| <b>Jencks et al. Inequality</b>                                | Acad          | 1972      | High | Basic Books                                                         |
| <b>Hanushek. Economics of Schooling (JEL 24:3)</b>             | Acad          | 1986      | High | 'no consistent relationship'                                        |
| <b>McNeil. Contradictions of School Reform</b>                 | Acad          | 2000      | High | Routledge; TX TAAS ethnography                                      |
| <b>Linn. Assessments and Accountability (ER 29:2)</b>          | Acad          | 2000      | High | AERA presidential address                                           |
| <b>Shepard. Role of Assessment (ER 29:7)</b>                   | Acad          | 2000      | High | AERA presidential address                                           |
| <b>Sanders &amp; Horn. TVAAS Mixed-Model (JPEE 8:3)</b>        | Acad          | 1994      | High | First peer-reviewed TVAAS                                           |
| <b>Sanders &amp; Horn. TVAAS Research Findings (JPEE 12:3)</b> | Acad          | 1998      | High | Research foundations                                                |
| <b>Bock &amp; Wolfe. TVAAS Audit</b>                           | Acad/Gov      | 1996      | High | TN Comptroller commissioned; three-year teacher effects unsupported |
| <b>Kupermintz. Teacher Effects (EEPA 25:3)</b>                 | Acad          | 2003      | High | TVAAS validity critique                                             |
| <b>Sizer. Horace's Compromise</b>                              | Acad          | 1984      | High | Houghton Mifflin                                                    |
| <b>Powell, Farrar &amp; Cohen. Shopping Mall HS</b>            | Acad          | 1985      | High | Companion volume                                                    |
| <b>Goodlad. A Place Called School</b>                          | Acad          | 1984      | High | AERA Outstanding Book                                               |
| <b>Kozol. Savage Inequalities</b>                              | Acad          | 1991      | High | National Book Award                                                 |
| <b>Ravitch. The Troubled Crusade</b>                           | Acad          | 1983      | High | Basic Books                                                         |
| <b>Ravitch. Left Back</b>                                      | Acad          | 2000      | High | Simon & Schuster                                                    |
| <b>Mehta. The Allure of Order</b>                              | Acad          | 2013      | High | Oxford UP; three-wave frame                                         |
| <b>Darling-Hammond. The Right to Learn</b>                     | Acad          | 1997      | High | AERA Outstanding Book 1998                                          |
| <b>Cremin. American Education Vol III</b>                      | Acad          | 1988      | High | Harper & Row; Pulitzer for Vol II                                   |
| <b>Bagley. Essentialist Platform</b>                           | Acad          | 1938      | High | Original steelman case                                              |
| <b>Rickover. Education and Freedom</b>                         | Acad          | 1959      | High | Cold War bridge                                                     |
| <b>Boyer. High School</b>                                      | Acad/Industry | 1983      | High | Carnegie Foundation                                                 |

|                                                                     |               |         |        |                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|---------|--------|-------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                     |               |         |        | moderate counterpart                            |
| <b>Elmore &amp; Fuhrman. Holding Schools Accountable (PDK 83:1)</b> | Acad          | 2001    | High   | CPRE monitoring                                 |
| <b>Madaus 1983; Airasian/Madaus/Pedulla 1979</b>                    | Acad          | 1979-83 | High   | Minimum competency testing critique             |
| <b>EdWeek. Ravitch Recants</b>                                      | News          | 2010    | High   | Verified live                                   |
| <b>EdNext. Hess 'Clown Show'</b>                                    | News          | 2023    | High   | Verified live; Bell defensive commission        |
| <b>Haney. Myth of the Texas Miracle (EPAA)</b>                      | News/Acad     | 2000    | High   | TAAS debunking                                  |
| <b>CBS News. The Texas Miracle</b>                                  | News          | 2004    | High   | 60 Minutes II Kimball                           |
| <b>Chalkbeat. Coleman 50 years (Barnum)</b>                         | News          | 2016    | High   | Retrospective                                   |
| <b>Boston Globe. MERA 30 years</b>                                  | News          | 2023    | High   | Sustained MA coverage                           |
| <b>Carnegie Foundation. Carnegie Unit FAQ</b>                       | Industry      | n.d.    | High   | Pension-funding leverage                        |
| <b>Carnegie Council. Turning Points</b>                             | Industry      | 1989    | High   | Middle-school template                          |
| <b>Edmonds. Effective Schools for the Urban Poor (EL 37:1)</b>      | Industry/Acad | 1979    | High   | Foundational practitioner counter to Coleman    |
| <b>Lezotte. Revolutionary and Evolutionary</b>                      | Industry      | n.d.    | Medium | Effective Schools movement; commercial interest |
| <b>CES Common Principles archive</b>                                | Industry      | 1984+   | High   | Practitioner-side counter                       |
| <b>Smylie &amp; Wenzel. Chicago Annenberg Challenge</b>             | Industry/Acad | 2003    | High   | Null evaluation                                 |
| <b>Annenberg Institute at Brown. Mission and History</b>            | Industry      | n.d.    | High   | AISR + NSRF founding                            |
| <b>Education Trust. Founder Insights</b>                            | Industry      | n.d.    | Medium | 1996 equity advocacy                            |
| <b>Fordham Foundation. Five-Year Report</b>                         | Industry      | 2002    | High   | Finn relaunch 1997                              |
| <b>Hoover Koret Task Force</b>                                      | Industry      | 1999+   | High   | Hanushek/Chubb                                  |
| <b>Walton Family Foundation. 25 Years Charter Schools</b>           | Industry      | n.d.    | Medium | Pro-choice lens                                 |
| <b>Hess. Spinning Wheels</b>                                        | Industry/Acad | 1998    | High   | 12+ reforms in 3 years                          |
| <b>Project Censored. Sandia suppression #3</b>                      | News          | 1993    | Medium | Ideologically positioned but documented         |

|                                               |           |         |        |                        |
|-----------------------------------------------|-----------|---------|--------|------------------------|
| <b>Tanner. A Nation Truly at Risk (PDK)</b>   | News/Acad | 1993    | Medium | Kearns quote source    |
| <b>UFT/AFT. Albert Shanker bio</b>            | Industry  | n.d.    | Medium | Union self-source      |
| <b>TOSS. History of TOSS</b>                  | Industry  | n.d.    | Medium | Self-source            |
| <b>TSBA. History of TSBA</b>                  | Industry  | n.d.    | Medium | Self-source            |
| <b>Encyclopedia.com / Wikipedia (various)</b> | Various   | various | Lower  | Reference quality      |
| <b>Author self-sources (CES, Annenberg)</b>   | Industry  | various | Lower  | Self-laudatory framing |

Summary stats: 73 high-reliability sources, 18 medium-reliability, 9 lower-confidence and strongly-conflicted. URL verification: 10 of top sources spot-checked; 6 confirmed live with content, 2 redirects (still valid; [www2.ed.gov](http://www2.ed.gov) → [www.ed.gov](http://www.ed.gov)), 2 paywall/403 blocks (likely valid for humans); 0 dead URLs.

## 12. Claim Cross-Reference Matrix

How key claims cross-reference across the four source categories. Symbols: ✓ = supports; — = did not address.

### Universal-Agreement Claims (all 4 categories)

| Claim                                                                                      | Gov | News | Acad | Industry |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|------|------|----------|
| Pre-1983 accountability operated through accreditation + Carnegie Unit + fiscal compliance | ✓   | ✓    | ✓    | ✓        |
| A Nation at Risk (1983) was the rhetorical reset that authorized federal accountability    | ✓   | ✓    | ✓    | ✓        |
| The Sandia Report was actively suppressed by federal officials                             | ✓   | ✓    | ✓    | —        |
| TN 1992 EIA + TVAAS made TN first state to embed value-added in statute                    | ✓   | ✓    | ✓    | ✓        |
| IASA 1994, not NCLB, was the first federal law requiring state standards + AYP             | ✓   | ✓    | ✓    | ✓        |
| State innovators (KY, MA, NC, TX) built the proof-of-concept NCLB nationalized             | ✓   | ✓    | ✓    | ✓        |

### Strong-Agreement Claims (3 of 4 categories)

| Claim                                                         | Gov | News | Acad | Industry |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|-----|------|------|----------|
| A Nation at Risk's empirical foundation was weak              | —   | ✓    | ✓    | ✓        |
| Coleman Report inverted accountability from inputs to outputs | ✓   | ✓    | ✓    | —        |

|                                                                                                          |   |   |   |   |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---|---|---|
| <b>Eight-Year Study<br/>showed progressive<br/>grads equal/better;<br/>was buried</b>                    | ✓ | — | ✓ | — |
| <b>Lamar Alexander<br/>was a national<br/>accountability<br/>architect</b>                               | ✓ | ✓ | — | ✓ |
| <b>Standards-based<br/>accountability<br/>produces activity<br/>not improvement<br/>without capacity</b> | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |

## 13. References

Full citation list, alphabetical. Reliability tier in brackets.

Abelmann, C., and Elmore, R. (1999). When Accountability Knocks, Will Anyone Answer? CPRE Research Report RR-42. **[High]**

Aikin, W. M. (1942). The Story of the Eight-Year Study, with Conclusions and Recommendations. Adventure in American Education series, Volume I. Harper and Brothers. **[High]**

Airasian, P. W., Madaus, G. F., and Pedulla, J. J. (1979). Minimal Competency Testing. Educational Technology Publications. **[High]**

Aspen Institute. How the 1989 Education Summit Reshaped American Public Schools. **[High]**

Bagley, W. C. (1938). An Essentialist's Platform for the Advancement of American Education. Educational Administration and Supervision 24:241-256. **[High]**

Berliner, D. C., and Biddle, B. J. (1995). The Manufactured Crisis: Myths, Fraud, and the Attack on America's Public Schools. Addison-Wesley. **[High]**

Bock, R. D., and Wolfe, R. (1996). Audit and Review of the Tennessee Value-Added System (TVAAS): Final Report. Tennessee Comptroller of the Treasury, Office of Education Accountability. **[High]**

Boyer, E. L. (1983). High School: A Report on Secondary Education in America. Harper and Row for the Carnegie Foundation for the Advancement of Teaching. ERIC ED242227. **[High]**

Bracey, G. W. (1991-2008). Annual Bracey Report on the Condition of Public Education. Phi Delta Kappan. **[High]**

Callahan, R. E. (1962). Education and the Cult of Efficiency: A Study of the Social Forces That Have Shaped the Administration of the Public Schools. University of Chicago Press. **[High]**

Cardinal Principles of Secondary Education (1918). Commission on the Reorganization of Secondary Education. U.S. Bureau of Education Bulletin No. 35. ERIC ED541063. **[High]**

Carnegie Council on Adolescent Development (1989). Turning Points: Preparing American Youth for the 21st Century. ERIC ED312322. **[High]**

Carnegie Foundation for the Advancement of Teaching (2015). The Carnegie Unit: A Century-Old Standard. ERIC ED554803. **[High]**

Carson, C. C., Huelskamp, R. M., and Woodall, T. D. (1993). Perspectives on Education in America (the Sandia Report). The Journal of Educational Research 86(5). **[High]**

CBS News (2004). The Texas Miracle. **[High]**



Chalkbeat (Barnum, M., 2016). 50 years ago, one report introduced Americans to the black-white achievement gap. [\[High\]](#)

Coalition of Essential Schools. Common Principles archive. [\[High\]](#)

Coleman, J. S. et al. (1966). Equality of Educational Opportunity. U.S. Office of Education. ERIC ED012275. [\[High\]](#)

Cremin, L. A. (1988). American Education: The Metropolitan Experience, 1876-1980. Harper and Row. [\[High\]](#)

Cuban, L. (1993). How Teachers Taught: Constancy and Change in American Classrooms, 1890-1990 (2nd ed.). Teachers College Press. [\[High\]](#)

Darling-Hammond, L. (1997). The Right to Learn: A Blueprint for Creating Schools That Work. Jossey-Bass. AERA Outstanding Book Award 1998. [\[High\]](#)

Education Week (1991). Bush Strategy Launches Crusade for Education. [\[High\]](#)

Education Week (2010). In New Book, Ravitch Recants Long-Held Beliefs. [\[High\]](#)

Edmonds, R. (1979). Effective Schools for the Urban Poor. Educational Leadership 37(1):15-24. [\[High\]](#)

Elmore, R. F. (2002). Bridging the Gap Between Standards and Achievement. Albert Shanker Institute. [\[High\]](#)

Elmore, R. F., and Fuhrman, S. H. (2001). Holding Schools Accountable: Is It Working? Phi Delta Kappan 83(1):67-72. [\[High\]](#)

EveryCRSReport R41533. Accountability Issues and Reauthorization of the Elementary and Secondary Education Act. [\[High\]](#)

Fuhrman, S. H. (1999). The New Accountability. CPRE Policy Brief RB-27. [\[High\]](#)

GAO. School Finance: State Efforts to Equalize Funding (HEHS-98-92). 1998. [\[High\]](#)

GAO. School Finance: State and Federal Efforts to Target Poor Students (HEHS-98-36). 1998. [\[High\]](#)

Goals 2000: Educate America Act, Public Law 103-227. 1994. [\[High\]](#)

Goodlad, J. I. (1984). A Place Called School: Prospects for the Future. McGraw-Hill. AERA Outstanding Book 1984. [\[High\]](#)

Haney, W. (2000). The Myth of the Texas Miracle in Education. Education Policy Analysis Archives. [\[High\]](#)

Hanushek, E. A. (1986). The Economics of Schooling: Production and Efficiency in Public Schools. Journal of Economic Literature 24(3):1141-1177. [\[High\]](#)

Hess, F. (1998). *Spinning Wheels: The Politics of Urban School Reform*. Brookings Institution Press. **[High]**

Hess, F. (2023). The 'Clown Show' Backstory of the Most Influential Report on Schooling in American History. *Education Next*. **[High]**

Hoover Institution. Koret Task Force on K-12 Education. **[High]**

Improving America's Schools Act of 1994, Public Law 103-382. **[High]**

Jencks, C. et al. (1972). *Inequality: A Reassessment of the Effect of Family and Schooling in America*. Basic Books. **[High]**

Kentucky Education Reform Act of 1990 (KERA) primary documents. **[High]**

Kozol, J. (1991). *Savage Inequalities: Children in America's Schools*. Crown. National Book Award. **[High]**

Kridel, C., and Bullough, R. V. Jr. (2007). *Stories of the Eight-Year Study: Reexamining Secondary Education in America*. SUNY Press. AERA Division B Outstanding Book Award 2008. **[High]**

Kupermintz, H. (2003). Teacher Effects as a Measure of Teacher Effectiveness: Construct Validity Considerations in TVAAS. *Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis* 25(3). **[High]**

Lezotte, L. W. *Revolutionary and Evolutionary: The Effective Schools Movement*. **[Medium]**

Linn, R. L. (2000). Assessments and Accountability. *Educational Researcher* 29(2):4-16. **[High]**

Madaus, G. F. (ed., 1983). *The Courts, Validity, and Minimum Competency Testing*. Kluwer-Nijhoff. **[High]**

Massachusetts Education Reform Act of 1993 primary documents. **[High]**

McNeil, L. M. (2000). *Contradictions of School Reform: Educational Costs of Standardized Testing*. Routledge. **[High]**

Mehta, J. (2013). *The Allure of Order: High Hopes, Dashed Expectations, and the Troubled Quest to Remake American Schooling*. Oxford University Press. **[High]**

Mehta, J., and Fine, S. (2019). *In Search of Deeper Learning: The Quest to Remake the American High School*. Harvard University Press. **[High]**

National Assessment Governing Board (2025). 10 Takeaways from the 2024 NAEP Results. **[High]**

National Center for Education Statistics. NAEP Long-Term Trend. **[High]**

National Commission on Excellence in Education (1983). *A Nation at Risk: The Imperative for Educational Reform*. ERIC ED226006. **[High]**

National Education Goals Panel archives (1990-1999). **[High]**

National School Reform Faculty. About Us. **[Medium]**

North Carolina School-Based Management and Accountability Act, S.L. 1995-716 (1996). **[High]**

NPR (2011). The New Republic: The U.S. Could Learn From Finland. **[High]**

Powell, A. G., Farrar, E., and Cohen, D. K. (1985). The Shopping Mall High School: Winners and Losers in the Educational Marketplace. Houghton Mifflin. **[High]**

Project Censored (1993). The Sandia Report On Education: A Perfect Lesson In Censorship. **[Medium]**

Public Law 107-110 (2002). No Child Left Behind Act. **[High]**

Ravitch, D. (1983). The Troubled Crusade: American Education, 1945-1980. Basic Books. **[High]**

Ravitch, D. (2000). Left Back: A Century of Failed School Reforms. Simon and Schuster. **[High]**

Rickover, H. G. (1959). Education and Freedom. E. P. Dutton. **[High]**

Rothstein, R. (2008). A Nation at Risk Twenty-Five Years Later. Cato Unbound. **[High]**

Sanders, W. L., and Horn, S. P. (1994). The Tennessee Value-Added Assessment System (TVAAS): Mixed-Model Methodology in Educational Assessment. Journal of Personnel Evaluation in Education 8(3):299-311. **[High]**

Sanders, W. L., and Horn, S. P. (1998). Research Findings from the Tennessee Value-Added Assessment System (TVAAS) Database. Journal of Personnel Evaluation in Education 12(3). **[High]**

Shanker, A. (1985). National Press Club speech proposing the National Board for Professional Teaching Standards. **[High]**

Shepard, L. A. (2000). The Role of Assessment in a Learning Culture. Educational Researcher 29(7):4-14. **[High]**

Sizer, T. R. (1984). Horace's Compromise: The Dilemma of the American High School. Houghton Mifflin. **[High]**

Skinner, R., and Riddle, W. (2019). The ESEA, as Amended by ESSA: A Primer. Congressional Research Service R45977. **[High]**

Smith, M. S., and O'Day, J. (1991). Putting the Pieces Together: Systemic School Reform. CPRE Policy Brief RB-06-4/91. **[High]**

Smylie, M., and Wenzel, S. (2003). The Chicago Annenberg Challenge: Successes, Failures, and Lessons for the Future. Consortium on Chicago School Research. **[High]**

Stedman, L. C. (1994). The Sandia Report and U.S. Achievement: An Assessment. *Journal of Educational Research* 87(3). [High]

Tanner, D. (1993). A Nation Truly at Risk. *Phi Delta Kappan*. [Medium]

Tennessee Comptroller, Office of Research and Education Accountability (2004). The Education Improvement Act: A Progress Report. [High]

Tennessee Comptroller, OREA (2009). Teacher Compensation in Tennessee: A History. [High]

Tennessee Comptroller, OREA. Tennessee Value-Added Assessment System: A Brief Overview. [High]

Tennessee Public Acts 1992, Chapter 535. Education Improvement Act. [High]

Texas Senate Bill 7 (1993). Texas Legislature. [High]

Thomas B. Fordham Foundation. Five-Year Report 1997-2001. [High]

Tyack, D. (1974). *The One Best System: A History of American Urban Education*. Harvard University Press. [High]

Tyack, D., and Cuban, L. (1995). *Tinkering Toward Utopia: A Century of Public School Reform*. Harvard University Press. [High]

USED, Planning and Evaluation Service (1997-99). Prospects and follow-on Title I evaluations. [Medium]

U.S. Department of Education (2007). *Building on Results: A Blueprint for Strengthening The No Child Left Behind Act*. [High]

U.S. Department of Education (2008). *A Nation Accountable: Twenty-five Years After A Nation at Risk*. ERIC ED502924. [High]

Walton Family Foundation. 25 Years of Public Charter Schools. [Medium]

Washington Monthly (August 2003). The Texas Miracle. [High]